

Guideline Title: Tourniquet Therapy

Guideline Number: GUID-3203-PR006

Issue date: 09/09/2014	Replaces Dept. Policy:
Revision dates: 4/30/24	Developed by: Air Care Team
Approved by: Dr. Christopher Hunter, MD Air Care Team Medical Director	Approved by:
Signature: 	Signature:
Department Numbers: 3203	

- I. **PURPOSE:** To stop blood loss and provide hemorrhage control by applying pressure to an artery using Combat Application Tourniquet (CAT) or a SWAT-T (Stretch, Wrap, and Tuck Tourniquet).
- II. **DEFINITIONS:**
- III. **DEPARTMENT GUIDELINE:**
 - A. **Indications:** To control potentially fatal hemorrhagic wounds only after other means of stopping blood loss have failed (direct pressure, a pressure dressing, wound packing) such as a mangled extremity or traumatic amputation.
 - B. **Contraindications:** Do not place tourniquet over joint.
 - C. Apply appropriate personal protective equipment (PPE).
 - D. Expose the extremity by removing clothing in proximity to the injury.
 - E. **Procedure for CAT:**
 - i. Place directly over exposed skin at least 5 cm proximal to the injury.
 - ii. Route the self-adhering band around the extremity.
 - iii. Pass the band through the outside slit of the buckle.
 - iv. Pull the self-adhering band tight.
 - v. Twist the rod until bright red bleeding stops and the distal pulse is eliminated.
 - vi. Lock the rod in place with the clip.
 - F. **Procedure for SWAT-T:**
 - i. Consider placing bandage material in or around wound.
 - ii. Wrap the SWAT-T above the wound area. Wrap once around the extremity to ensure the tourniquet is secure against the skin.
 - iii. Pull the tourniquet tight against the extremity until the diamonds become squares.
 - iv. Wrap around the extremity. On the last wrap, create a loop, then tuck the end under the loop. The SWAT-T will grip itself to remain in place.
 - G. **Reassessment, Continuation and Removal**
 - i. Recheck for bleeding and distal pulse. If bleeding is not controlled, consider additional tightening or apply a second tourniquet.
 - ii. Clearly record the date/time of application of the tourniquet and relay this information to the receiving facility.

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- iii. Keep tourniquet on throughout the transport – a correctly applied tourniquet should only be removed by the receiving hospital.

IV. **DOCUMENTATION:** EMS chart

V. **REFERENCES:**

- A. <http://swat-t.com/#intro>
- B. www.stopthebleed.org